
THE ESPY'S
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CURRENT AUDIENCE COMPOSITION



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CURRENT AUDIENCE COMPOSITION

- 72% of the social media conversation is **driven by men**.
  - This is down from 83% in 2015, indicating a shift away from a gender-specific interest.
  - Adopting additional social media platforms and posting more representative content may increase female engagement.
- Gen Z and Millennials account for 47% of the conversation.
  - The younger segment of the ESPYs audience is drawn to trends and creative partnerships and content, engaging with posts that align with their current interests.
  - With 39% of social media conversations driven by the 45+ audience, the ESPYs age distribution consists of more Gen X and Baby Boomers than other award-events.
- By providing content for enthusiastic fans of all ages, the ESPYs encourage **connection and interaction between generations**.
  - #ESPYs has generated 220 million views on TikTok, indicating potential for widespread, culturally relevant conversations on socials



AUDIENCE SENTIMENT

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AUDIENCE SENTIMENT

- With overwhelmingly **positive sentiment**, the ESPYs provide a largely **uncontroversial space** to promote both rising and established brands (94%, twitter-based quid sentiment analysis).
- High volumes of impressions and engagement suggest **probable virality**, with speeches, awards, and red carpet clips generating hundreds of millions of impressions (Quid, 2023).
- A notably high engagement rate nearing 3% on top posts, & roughly 6 times the average for Twitter, indicates ultra-immersed audiences (Statista, 2022).

AUDIENCE SENTIMENT

KEY INSIGHTS

- The ESPYs can connect with these audiences by i**ncreasing their social presence** on X and TikTok
  - Highlight clips of the ceremony reposted, interviews with nominees, nomination announcements
- Keeping the event **focused on the athletes** and accomplishments is key
  - Advertising to fans on social is important, but it cannot overshadow the athletes and their awards; needs to be emphasized through advertisements in a respectful way for fans to tune in
- The ESPYs allow fans to peer into the personal lives of athletes through their accomplishments on and off the field
  - Seen through trending awards speeches reposted on TikTok and YT shorts
- Main demo: Male Gen Zers and Millennials, who use platforms like X (Twitter) and TikTok to keep up with sports news
  - Great potential for impressions on social

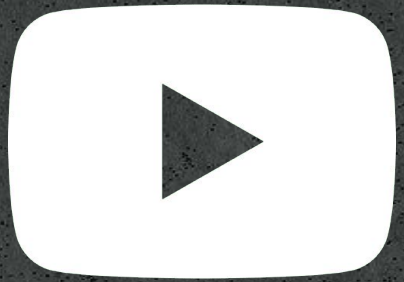
PLATFORMS FOR GEN Z



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PLATFORMS FOR GEN Z

Focus mostly on Tik Tok and YouTube







SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

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SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

- How Gen Z perceives advertisements related to sports content

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Advertisements resonating most effectively with Gen Z are those that prioritize authenticity, personal narratives, and emotional connections.**
  - **Gen Z would rather participate in niche sports than follow traditional ones.**
    - Nontraditional sports allow for direct engagement, and due to the propagation of digital media, individuals can compete and try to hone and improve their skills as opposed to passively watching professionals. Gen Z prefers not to be stagnant. They want to be a part of the action and not a bystander.

Source: https://medium.com/instant-sponsor/generation-z-is-transforming-how-sports-content-is-watched-and-distributed-f46696b800c9

KEY INSIGHTS

How Gen Z perceives advertisements related to sports content

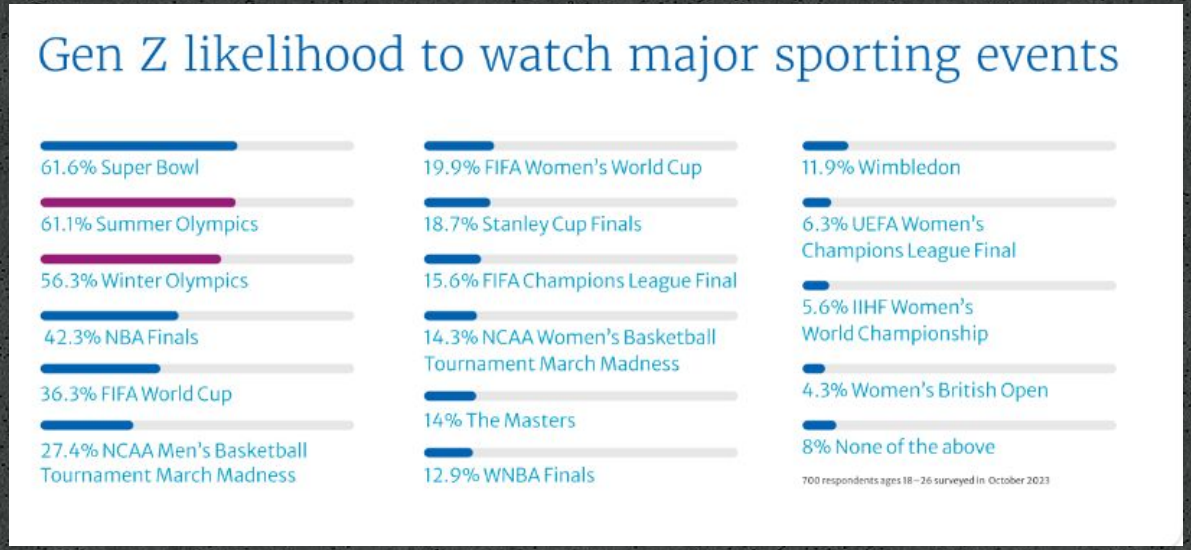
SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

- **Advertisements resonating most effectively with Gen Z are those that prioritize authenticity, personal narratives, and emotional connections.**
  - Advertisements that stand out according to Gen Z highlight athletes and their stories (39.3%).
    - EX: **Gen Z prefers the Summer Games to the Winter Games**
      - More than two-thirds of Gen Z are likely to tune into the Summer Olympics (Compared to 56% who are likely to tune into the Winter Olympics).
      - The Summer Olympics traditionally include broader sports that align more closely with the preferences and interests of Generation Z. Summer sports often include more widely followed and popular activities such as *athletics*, *gymnastics*, *swimming*, and various team sports.
  - With Generation Z, whose media consumption is heavily influenced by digital platforms, the more extensive coverage and online presence of summer sports and athletes could play a pivotal role in capturing their attention to the Summer Olympics.
    - Notable figures from summer sports, such as basketball, gymnastics, and athletics, often are more popular in mainstream media and on social platforms. For instance, basketball stars like LeBron James have 159 millions followers on Instagram.
  - The appeal for the Summer Olympics nearly matches that of the Super Bowl among Gen Z and far outranks other sporting events.

Source: https://medium.com/instant-sponsor/generation-z-is-transforming-how-sports-content-is-watched-and-distributed-f46696b800c9

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SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION



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SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Gen Z fans want a multi channel viewing experience**
  - Over 90% of Gen Z sports fans use social media to consume sports content, with their favorite content being game clips and highlights, live events, behind-the-scenes interviews and videos, as well as athletes' posts.
  - When attending a live sporting event in person, 43% of Gen Z fans use their mobile device to post to social media during the game.
  - 65% of Gen Z keep up with non-traditional sports by watching videos on YouTube/social media



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Source: https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/game-changing-generational-trends-and-shifts-in-tech-lead-to-the-era-of-immersive-sports-301863219.html

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Gen Z fans want a multi channel viewing experience**
  - A majority of Gen Z fans follow an athlete online. As a result, 46% of Gen Z fans will watch a live sporting event from home, and 33% will attend a live sporting event in person.
    - Since 80% of Gen Z fans follow a professional athlete online and 90% use social media to consume sports media, ad placement on social media can resonate with Gen Z by including their favorite athletes to keep them engaged.
    - With 64% of Gen Z preferring steaming over broadcast, strategic placement of brands and athletes on streaming platforms can engage Gen Z.
    - With more fans encouraged to watch events because of their support for certain athletes, Disney has the opportunity to reach Gen Z niches.

Source: https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/game-changing-generational-trends-and-shifts-in-tech-lead-to-the-era-of-immersive-sports-301863219.html

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Gen Z fans want a multi channel viewing experience**
  - Nearly half (47%) of US consumers *increase* their online content consumption *leading up* to a major sporting event. The most popular forms of online content include social media, articles, and video clips.
    - **Anticipatory** advertising that engages consumers and increases “hype” for an event is a great opportunity for advertisers

Source: https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/game-changing-generational-trends-and-shifts-in-tech-lead-to-the-era-of-immersive-sports-301863219.html

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Fans want subscription video on demand features that enhance, but don't overshadow, the game**
  - Streaming services have the potential to surpass the experience of watching sports on cable or broadcast TV, with 64% of Gen Z, 71% of millennial, and 52% of Gen X fans saying that they have a better viewing experience when watching a specific sporting event on a specific streaming provider than on cable or broadcast television.
    - Streaming platforms like Disney+ collect extensive data on user preferences, watch history, and content engagement. This allows for highly personalized ad targeting, ensuring that advertisements align with users' interests and viewing habits.
    - Streaming platforms are perceived as premium spaces for content consumption, advertisers find that the better environment of streaming services aligns well with their brand image.

Source: https://www2.deloitte.com/us/en/insights/industry/media-and-entertainment/immersive-sports-fandom.html

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Fans want subscription video on demand features that enhance, but don't overshadow, the game**
  - Some fans want new features from their SVOD services, such as real-time statistics and analytics, different camera angles, or watching the game from an athlete's POV.
  - Bonus content that is included with streaming live sporting events (pre/post-game interviews and content) is a motivator for audiences to watch.
  - There are frustrations with streaming sports and a desire for a less fragmented, simpler experience, with 70% of Gen Z and 80% of millennial fans saying they'd be willing to pay extra for a streaming service that had all the sports they want to watch in one place.
  - Looking at the issue of advertising, 66% of non-betting fans say they’re tired of seeing so much advertising around sports betting (compared to 48% of bettors).
  - 69% of Gen Z say advertisers are a welcome part of non-traditional sports

Source: https://www2.deloitte.com/us/en/insights/industry/media-and-entertainment/immersive-sports-fandom.html

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Gen Z fans crave a social and community based sports experience**
  - Gen Z does not see sports as defined by leagues, but as something, they can participate in and recreate with their friends. Therefore, advertising companies must take notice of this shift and modify their consumption methods.
    - Community building via social media
      - We flock to social media to find niche communities. These niche communities are opportunities for companies to tap into when advertising and trying to reach these target audiences
  - According to John West, founder of Whistle, a sports and entertainment media brand, “Generation Z is also more likely to find content when it’s shared by a friend and allows them to engage directly.”
    - Therefore, it is imperative for platform creators and influencers to establish a genuine and authentic relationship with their audience. Gen Z must feel they can trust those who are distributing the content.

Source: https://medium.com/instant-sponsor/generation-z-is-transforming-how-sports-content-is-watched-and-distributed-f46696b800c9#:~:text=Gen%20Z%20must%20feel%20they,the%20back%20of%20the%20jersey.

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

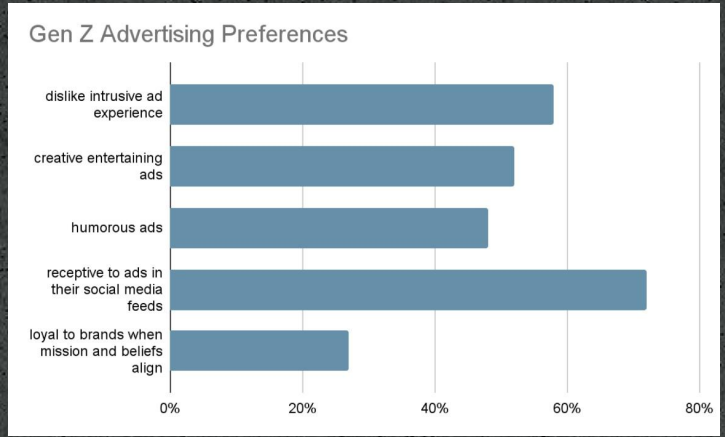
- Gen Z fans crave a social and community based sports experience
  - The focus has also become less about the team and more about the name on the back of the jersey. “This generation views social influences and creators as their new celebrities,” stated West.
    - So, brands must be able to showcase players outside of the arena; give the audience the personalized experience they are craving. Gen Z will fall in love with a player because of their personality, not because of their team name.
      - EX: Michael Jordan x Nike “Maybe it’s my fault” commercial
        - This commercial sums up everything you need to know about Michael Jordan. Yes, he is the best basketball player of all time, but it is not because he was born that way. He makes it a point of telling us that he worked harder than anyone every day of his life to get where he was. This dominance made us think that he didn’t even have to try. On the contrary, he reminds us that those who think that’s the case are just making excuses.

Source: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9zSVu76AX3I&t=58s

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SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

- What kind of ads does Gen Z like?
  - Link 1
  - Link 2



Sources: https://www.supermarketnews.com/news/here-s-how-gen-z-wants-see-ads

https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/gen-z-expects-advertising-to-be-purpose-driven-unobtrusive-and-entertaining-according-to-new-ncsolutions-analysis-301815824.html

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SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

- Gen Z expects advertising to **serve a purpose**:
  - Ads should convey a distinct purpose, aligning with the values, social causes, or messages advocated by ESPY.
  - Ads with a **social message** resonate well with Gen Z; 17% like ads when they are aligned with the social messaging of the ad
  - 27% of Gen Z are loyal to brands when the **brand's mission aligns with their own beliefs**
  - Gen Z preference for **unobtrusive advertising**:
    - Gen Z strongly dislikes intrusive or disruptive ad experiences, with 58% expressing a dislike for ads interrupting their content.
    - Connect with ESPY, advertisers should ensure that promotional content integrates without disrupting the viewer's experience.

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

- Gen Z prefer engagement through **humorous and entertaining content**
  - 52% of Gen Z expresses a preference for creative and entertaining ads
  - To capture the attention of Gen Z in sports-related advertising, including ESPY content, advertisers should incorporating humor and entertainment elements
- Gen Z shows strong **receptiveness to social media ads**
  - 72% of Gen Z is most receptive to experiencing ads in their social media feeds.
  - Given the receptivity to ads on social media, including platforms like YouTube, advertisers associated with sports events like ESPY should use social media channels to reach and engage Gen Z.
  - Nearly three-in-four Gen Zers (72%) say they're open to seeing ads in their newsfeeds, compared to 28% who say they're receptive to ads on cable TV and 20% who say they're open to broadcast TV advertising
- Gen Z and millennials would tolerate ads on streaming services if the prices of platforms were lower
  - Around 39% are interested in using a streaming service with ads for a lower price
  - Around 29% already use a streaming service with ads
  - Around 31% would not be interested in using a streaming service with ads for a lower price

Sources: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-attention-span/

https://www.statista.com/statistics/1409505/gen-z-millennials-interest-streaming-with-ads/#statisticContainer

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

- Gen Z thoughts
  - 82% of Gen Z admit to skipping ads whenever they can
  - Bumper ads are ideal for Gen Z because they're only **6-seconds long** and they can't skip forward, ensuring your audience sees and hears your message.
  - Brand loyalty/brand values
    - Gen Z is a large and diverse generation that isn't afraid to call brands out and demand accountability.
    - Be **authentic** to your brand at every turn
  - 60% of Gen Z look to others whom they can **trust**, with recommendations from family and friends bearing significant weight in their purchasing decisions.
    - Use professional athletes
  - Embrace over the top advertising and its cost-effective targeting capabilities

Source: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-advertising-strategies/

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SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

Introduction: Capturing Gen Z's interest within eight seconds or less is crucial, and this can be achieved by recognizing their preference for interactive and fast-paced content. Given their upbringing in a digital environment, Gen Z is naturally drawn to experiences that are not only engaging but also concise.

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Advertisers must take control of Gen Z's short attention span**
  - EX: Fantasy Sports
    - This can be achieved through in-game branding, real-time updates, and personalized content that resonates with the preferences and behaviors of Gen Z users. By blending marketing seamlessly into the fabric of daily fantasy sports, companies can engage this younger audience in a manner that is both relevant and captivating, making the most of those crucial first eight seconds.
  - Aim for **under 2 minutes**
    - Keep in mind that Gen Z switches between five devices. The objective is to communicate the message in the least period of time while maintaining brand messaging

Source: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-attention-span/

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SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Advertisers must take control of Gen Z's short attention span**
  - Tell a **story**
    - Or better yet - help them tell their story. Doing so will ensure that it will appeal to your target audience.
    - Gen Z can spot a fake from a mile away. Be **relatable**, be **genuine** and most importantly **be yourself**.
  - Clean Visuals
    - Hire a video production agency so your visuals are **clear** and of **high quality**.
  - Add **Subtitles**
    - Not only will this increase the likelihood that someone will watch until the end, but it also improves the understanding of your video; two things that are crucial for ad recall.
      - This also plays into disability awareness and shows inclusiveness to those who are disabled and need assistance in viewing

Source: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-attention-span/

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Advertisers must take control of Gen Z's short attention span**
  - **Vertical video**
    - Gen Z is more likely to watch videos on their phones and when it comes to social media, vertical video has a 5% higher chance of being watched to completion than horizontal
    - **90% of millennials** prefer using their phones in the vertical position
      - Vertical video is a natural fit for how they use their devices, making it more appealing
      - Vertical video is the ideal choice for reaching and engaging with Gen Z and millennials due to the popularity of platforms including TikTok and Instagram
    - EX: YouTube shorts and YouTube ads
      - Now, some appear vertical automatically to fit your phone and no longer have to be horizontal
      - This shows versatility and how in tune YouTube is with the mobile world as they are cognisant that most users are viewing their content on phones

Sources: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-attention-span/

https://www.socialmotionfilms.com/post/advantages-of-vertical-video-content#:~:text=Studies%20have%20shown%20that%20vertical,%2Dthrough%20rates%2C%20and%20shares.

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

KEY INSIGHTS

- **Advertisers must take control of Gen Z's short attention span**
  - Use **Hashtags**
    - Hashtags connect brands with new audiences, thus increasing reach.
    - They also help **tap into trends**, which is especially important for short-form videos because they can quickly become outdated.
  - Include a **call to action**
    - Give the viewer a next step

Source: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-attention-span/

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

How branding and sponsorship in the context of ESPY or sports-related content impact Gen Z's engagement with advertisements?

- **TikTok**
  - **The volume of sponsorship deals on TikTok has increased 4x since 2021, and the volume of branded engagement generated by TikTok has increased by over six million in the same time frame.**
  - As Gen Z gravitates towards TikTok, incorporating elements of TikTok-style content and engagement strategies into ESPY promotions may resonate well with this demographic.
    - Short-form videos are especially popular amongst members of Gen Z

SOCIAL AD PERCEPTION

How branding and sponsorship in the context of ESPY or sports-related content impact Gen Z's engagement with advertisements?

- **YouTube**
  - The growth of YouTube within the demographic has influenced sports leagues to enhance their YouTube content, **with 40% of Major Pro Sports properties including a YouTube sponsorship element in the past year.**
    - ESPYs can leverage this trend by creating engaging and authentic content for YouTube to fit with Gen Z's preferences.
  - YouTube's diverse content ecosystem aligns with Gen Z's desire for **authenticity** and **relatability**.

How branding and sponsorship in the context of ESPY or sports-related content impact Gen Z's engagement with advertisements?

- **Reaching Gen Z With an Athlete's Personal Brand**
  - **Authenticity:**
    - Gen Z appreciates transparency. They are more likely to respond positively to an athlete who is **genuine in their personal brand and marketing endeavors**. Ensure that the athlete's endorsement **feels sincere** and is not just a paid promotion. The athlete should genuinely like and use the product or service they're endorsing.
  - **Social Media & Digital Platforms:**
    - Gen Z lives online, particularly on social media platforms like Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube. Athletes should **leverage their personal social media accounts** to reach this demographic. This could include **creating engaging content** like behind-the-scenes training videos, vlogs, Q&As, or challenges that incorporate the brand in a **natural way**.
  - **Collaboration with Influencers:**
    - Along with athletes, Gen Z is also heavily influenced by online personalities. Partnering with these influencers for collaborative promotions can **tap into their significant following** and **extend the reach** of the athlete's personal brand.

Source: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-attention-span/

How branding and sponsorship in the context of ESPY or sports-related content impact Gen Z's engagement with advertisements?

- **Reaching Gen Z With an Athlete's Personal Brand**
  - **Social Responsibility:**
    - Gen Z is notably socially and environmentally conscious. Athletes who **stand for causes**, **contribute to their communities**, and **promote sustainability** are more likely to resonate with this generation. Associating the athlete's brand with charitable initiatives or environmental efforts can help in connecting with Gen Z.
  - **Interactive Content:**
    - This generation appreciates interactive and engaging content. Consider creating campaigns that involve **user-generated content**, like asking fans to participate in a challenge, create a TikTok dance, or design a new product. This not only engages Gen Z consumers but also helps to amplify the reach of the campaign.
  - **Personal Connection:**
    - Gen Z values a personal connection with their idols. Encourage the athlete to **interact directly with their fans** through social media - responding to comments, hosting live streams, or even following back fans. This direct interaction can foster a stronger connection between the athlete, their fans, and the associated brand.

Source: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-attention-span/

How branding and sponsorship in the context of ESPY or sports-related content impact Gen Z's engagement with advertisements?

- **Reaching Gen Z With an Athlete's Personal Brand**
  - **Mobile-First Approach:**
    - Most Gen Z consumers use their smartphones to access content and shop online. Make sure that all content, websites, and shopping platforms are **mobile-friendly**.
  - **Use of Visuals and Short-form Content:**
    - Gen Z's attention span tends to be shorter due to the abundance of content available. Using **visuals, infographics, short videos, or GIFs** can be more effective in getting their attention. Platforms like **TikTok** and **Instagram Stories** are ideal for this kind of content.
  - **Celebrity Collaborations:**
    - Many Gen Z individuals are also captivated by musicians, actors, and other celebrities. Pairing an athlete with a celebrity from another industry for a **collaborative promotion** can **generate significant buzz** and reach a **broader audience**.
  - No matter the strategy, the key is to ensure that any marketing efforts using an athlete's brand **align with the interests, values, and communication preferences** of Gen Z.

Source: https://www.colormatics.com/article/gen-z-attention-span/